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LOST BATTLE From left, DMK chief Stalin visits Kolathur on May 5, post-loss; AIADMK's Palaniswamy campaigning in Chennai

takeaway from the 2026 election is that Tamil Nadu has entered an uncertain period where charisma, digital mobilisation and generational change are reshaping electoral behaviour faster than traditional party structures can respond. This election had a total of 57.3 million eligible voters, of which about 12.2 million (roughly 21 per cent) were in the 18-29 age bracket, the so-called GenZ voters. Whether this digital age cohort played an outsize role in the verdict is also now a point of discussion.

The age connection carried on to TVK's candidate base too, with the average age being less than 40. A perfect example of how this segued into the TVK story was the much-talked about winner from Virugambakkam seat in south Chennai: 30-year-old R. Sabarinathan, son of Vijay's long-time driver and close aide Rajendran.

The party, though, positioned itself carefully even within this environment. Vijay avoided presenting himself as a conventional ideological crusader. The TVK's 40-point manifesto also kept it simple, emphasising jobs generation, women's welfare, MSME revival and governance transparency.

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Dravid Majors Lose the Plot

Kolathur, Stalin's long-time seat, and Chennai emerged as the clearest symbols of the DMK's fall in 2026. Stalin's defeat to former close aide, V.S. Babu of the TVK, carried enormous political import. Across the Greater Chennai region, the DMK was reduced to two seats, a stunning reversal in what had long been one of the party's strongest urban bastions.

For the AIADMK, the result is troubling because it suggests not merely electoral defeat but long-term erosion. It is becoming increasingly clear that it may never reclaim the emotional connect and charismatic leadership once provided by Jayalalithaa and MGR. The emergence of TVK may accelerate this diminution, with younger anti-DMK voters who once viewed the AIADMK as a default alternative shifting to Vijay's party.

As for the BJP, now reduced to one seat, it may be electorally limited in Tamil Nadu, but could still be an indirect beneficiary of the political fragmentation. If the state enters a prolonged phase of fractured mandates, the BJP may gain relevance as a negotiating force.

Meanwhile, the inexperience of Vijay's partymen is already starting to show. At least two TVK MLAs spoke in Hindi to journalists soon after their victory, drawing criticism on social media. "It sends the wrong signals in a state where linguistic identity remains politically sensitive. Tamil Nadu has traditionally been a place where even the prime minister addresses public events in English," noted one observer.

Indeed, the election has altered TN's political vocabulary in more ways than one. The electorate has not just voted for a new party, it has signalled impatience with established political structures and opened the door to a far more fluid political era. Whether this is transitional or permanent, only time will tell. ■